USER MANUAL

NOTE-MATE

Personal Notes & Reminder

A beginner-friendly guide to every feature and button

Built with React, Node.js, Express and MongoDB

Contents

1. Introduction

2. Purpose of NOTE-MATE

3. System requirements

4. Installation and setup

5. Home page

6. Registration

7. Login

8. Dashboard

9. Dashboard cards

10. Creating a note

11. Viewing a note

12. Editing a note

13. Deleting a note

14. Searching notes

15. Important notes

16. Categories

17. Tags

18. Creating reminders

19. Editing reminders

20. Deleting reminders

21. Completing reminders

22. Reminder priorities

23. Reminder search and filters

24. Notification system

25. Logout

26. MongoDB and data storage overview

27. Troubleshooting

28. Frequently encountered errors

Tip: every feature section below follows the same pattern - what it does, how to use it, what happens after you click, and any limitations.

1. Introduction

NOTE-MATE is a web application for keeping personal notes and reminders in one place. You write notes, sort them with categories and tags, mark important ones, and create reminders that alert you when their time arrives. Each person has a private account, so nobody else can see your notes or reminders.

NOTE-MATE has a React frontend (the pages you see in the browser), a Node.js and Express backend, and a MongoDB database.

This manual explains every working feature and every important button, in the order you are likely to use them.

2. Purpose of NOTE-MATE

- Keep study, work and personal notes organised instead of scattered across papers and chat apps.
- Find any note quickly with search, categories and tags.
- Remember deadlines and appointments with dated, timed reminders and priorities.
- See your workload at a glance on a dashboard whose numbers come from the database.

3. System requirements

Item	Requirement
Operating system	Windows, macOS or Linux
Node.js	Version 18 or newer (LTS recommended)
Database	MongoDB Community Server on your computer, or a free MongoDB Atlas cloud database
Browser	A current version of Chrome, Edge, Firefox or Safari
Internet	Needed only to install packages and for MongoDB Atlas; local MongoDB works offline

4. Installation and setup

The complete beginner steps, with common errors, are in **SETUP.md**. In short:

1. Install Node.js and set up MongoDB (local or Atlas).
2. Open a terminal in the **backend** folder and run `npm install`.
3. Copy `.env.example` to `.env` and fill in PORT, MONGODB_URI and JWT_SECRET.
4. Run `npm start`. The terminal should say that MongoDB is connected.
5. Open **http://localhost:5000** in your browser.

The React frontend is already built inside **frontend/dist** and is served by the backend, so you only run commands in the **backend** folder. Always use the address above; do not open files from the frontend folder directly.

Only if you want to edit the frontend code: open a second terminal in the **frontend** folder and run `npm install` then `npm run dev` (live-reload version at http://localhost:5173, with the backend still running). To refresh the version on port 5000, run `npm run build` in the frontend folder.

5. Home page

The home page is the first page visitors see. It introduces NOTE-MATE with the tagline *Manage your notes and reminders easily* and six feature cards (Notes, Reminders, Search, Categories, Important Notes, Notifications).

Button	What happens when you click it
Get Started	Opens the Register page so you can create an account.
Login	Opens the Login page.
Register	Opens the Register page.
Navbar: Home, About, Login, Register	Moves between the public pages. After you log in, the navbar changes to Dashboard, Notes, Reminders, About and Logout.
Menu (small screens)	Shows or hides the navigation links on phones.

6. Registration

WHAT IT DOES

Creates your personal account. Your password is turned into a secure hash before it is saved, so the real password is never stored.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Click **Register** in the navbar.
2. Type your **Name** and **Email**.
3. Type a **Password** of at least 6 characters and type it again in **Confirm Password**.
4. Click the **Register** button.

WHAT HAPPENS AFTER YOU CLICK

If everything is valid, your account is saved in MongoDB, you are logged in automatically and the Dashboard opens. If something is wrong, a red message appears above the form and nothing is saved. Possible messages: *All fields are required*, *Please enter a valid email address*, *Password must be at least 6 characters*, *Passwords do not match*, and *This email is already registered*.

IMPORTANT LIMITATIONS

Each email can be used for one account only. There is no password-reset feature, so remember your password.

7. Login

WHAT IT DOES

Proves who you are so you can see your own notes and reminders.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Click **Login** in the navbar.
2. Enter your **Email** and **Password**.
3. Click the **Login** button.

WHAT HAPPENS AFTER YOU CLICK

On success you are taken to the Dashboard. On failure a red message such as *Incorrect email or password* is shown. The button shows *Please wait...* while the server checks your details.

IMPORTANT LIMITATIONS

A login lasts 7 days, after which you must log in again. If you are already logged in and open the Login or Register page, you are sent straight to the Dashboard.

8. Dashboard

The Dashboard is your home screen after login. It greets you by name and shows a summary of your data. Everything on it is loaded from MongoDB each time the page opens; nothing is typed in by hand.

Part of the page	What it shows or does
+ New Note	Opens the Notes page with the New Note form already open.
+ New Reminder	Opens the Reminders page with the New Reminder form already open.
Statistic cards	Six counters (see the next section).
Recent Notes	Your 4 most recently updated notes, with category, date and an Important badge where it applies.
Upcoming Reminders	Up to 5 pending reminders dated today or later, earliest first, with priority, date and time.
View all notes / View all reminders	Opens the full Notes or Reminders page.

9. Dashboard cards

Card	How it is calculated
Total Notes	Number of notes you have saved.
Important Notes	Notes marked as important.
Total Reminders	Number of reminders you have saved.
Pending Reminders	Reminders not yet marked completed (this includes overdue ones).
Completed Reminders	Reminders you marked as completed.
Today's Reminders	Reminders dated today, whether pending or completed. Today is taken from your computer's date.

10. Creating a note

WHAT IT DOES

Saves a new note in your account.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Open **Notes** and click **+ New Note** (or use + New Note on the Dashboard).
2. Type a **Title** (required, up to 120 characters).
3. Type the **Content** (optional, up to 10,000 characters).
4. Choose a **Category** and optionally type **Tags** separated by commas, for example *DBMS, Assignment*.
5. Tick **Mark as important** if needed.
6. Click **Save Note**.

WHAT HAPPENS AFTER YOU CLICK

The form closes, a green message *Note created* appears and the new note shows as a card. If the title is empty, the red message *Title is required* appears and the form stays open. Click **Cancel**, press Esc, or click outside the form to close it without saving.

IMPORTANT LIMITATIONS

Notes are plain text. Formatting such as bold or images is not supported.

11. Viewing a note

WHAT IT DOES

Shows the complete note, because cards display only the first 120 characters of the content.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Find the note on the Notes page.
2. Click **View** on its card.

WHAT HAPPENS AFTER YOU CLICK

A window opens with the full title, category, tags, Important badge, content, created date and last-updated date. Click **Close** to return.

12. Editing a note

WHAT IT DOES

Changes the title, content, category, tags or importance of an existing note.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Click **Edit** on the note's card.
2. The form opens filled with the current values; change what you need.
3. Click **Save Note**.

WHAT HAPPENS AFTER YOU CLICK

The note is updated, the message *Note updated* appears, and its updated date changes to today. Because notes are sorted with important ones first and then by latest update, an edited note may move to the top.

13. Deleting a note

WHAT IT DOES

Permanently removes a note.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Click **Delete** on the note's card.
2. A *Please confirm* box asks whether to delete the note.
3. Click **Delete** to confirm or **Cancel** to keep it.

WHAT HAPPENS AFTER YOU CLICK

After confirming, the note is removed from MongoDB and the message *Note deleted* appears. Cancel changes nothing.

IMPORTANT LIMITATIONS

Deleted notes cannot be recovered. There is no recycle bin.

14. Searching notes

WHAT IT DOES

Finds notes by typing part of a word. The search checks the title, content, category and tags and ignores upper/lower case.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Open **Notes**.
2. Click the **Search notes...** box and start typing.

WHAT HAPPENS AFTER YOU CLICK

About a third of a second after you stop typing, the list updates to the matching notes. Clear the box to see all notes again. If nothing matches, the page shows *No notes found*.

IMPORTANT LIMITATIONS

Search works with partial text (for example *assig* finds *Assignment*). It can be combined with the category filter and the Important only checkbox, so all active conditions must match.

15. Important notes

WHAT IT DOES

Highlights notes you must not miss. Important notes get a coloured left edge and an Important badge, and are listed first.

HOW TO USE IT

1. **While creating or editing:** tick **Mark as important**.
2. **From a card:** click **Mark important**; click **Unmark** to remove it.
3. **To list only important notes:** tick **Important only** above the cards.

WHAT HAPPENS AFTER YOU CLICK

The note is updated immediately and a message such as *Marked as important* appears. The Dashboard's Important Notes counter changes accordingly.

16. Categories

Every note belongs to one category. The available categories are fixed: **College, Personal, Work, Project, Important** and **Other**. Choose one in the note form (default for new notes: Personal). To see only one category, pick it in the **All categories** drop-down above the cards; choose *All categories* to see everything again. Categories are also searched by the search box.

Limitation: you cannot create your own category names. The category named *Important* is separate from the Mark important option; they do not change each other.

17. Tags

Tags are short labels for finer organisation. Type them in the **Tags** box separated by commas. They appear on the card with a # sign, for example #DBMS #Assignment.

- Spaces around tags are removed and repeated tags are stored once.
- A note can keep up to 10 tags; extra tags are ignored.
- Tags are searchable: typing *DBMS* in the search box finds notes carrying that tag.
- To change tags, click **Edit**, change the Tags box and save.

18. Creating reminders

WHAT IT DOES

Saves a task with a date, time and priority so NOTE-MATE can alert you.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Open **Reminders** and click **+ New Reminder**.
2. Type the **Reminder Title** (required).
3. Optionally add a **Description**.
4. Choose the **Date** and **Time** (both required). The form starts with today and 9:00 AM.
5. Choose a **Priority**: Low, Medium or High.
6. Click **Save Reminder**.

WHAT HAPPENS AFTER YOU CLICK

The reminder is saved and appears as a card showing its priority, status, date and time. The message *Reminder created* appears. If a required field is empty, a red message keeps the form open.

IMPORTANT LIMITATIONS

Reminders are listed with the earliest date and time first. Times are shown in 12-hour format (for example 10:00 AM).

19. Editing reminders

WHAT IT DOES

Changes a reminder's title, description, date, time or priority.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Click **Edit** on the reminder's card.
2. Change the values you need.
3. Click **Save Reminder**.

WHAT HAPPENS AFTER YOU CLICK

The reminder is updated and *Reminder updated* appears. Editing also lets the reminder notify you again at its new time.

IMPORTANT LIMITATIONS

If you move a reminder to a time that has already passed, the alert appears right away.

20. Deleting reminders

WHAT IT DOES

Permanently removes a reminder.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Click **Delete** on the card.
2. In the *Please confirm* box click **Delete** (or **Cancel** to keep it).

WHAT HAPPENS AFTER YOU CLICK

The reminder is removed from MongoDB and *Reminder deleted* appears. The Dashboard counters update the next time the Dashboard opens.

IMPORTANT LIMITATIONS

Deleted reminders cannot be recovered.

21. Completing reminders

WHAT IT DOES

Marks a task as done, or puts it back to pending.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Click **Mark completed** on a pending reminder's card.
2. To undo, click **Mark pending** on a completed one.

WHAT HAPPENS AFTER YOU CLICK

A completed reminder shows a green Completed badge and a crossed-out title, and it stops being counted as pending or upcoming. The message *Marked as completed* or *Marked as pending* appears.

22. Reminder priorities

Priority	Colour on the card	Suggested use
High	Red	Deadlines and things that cannot be missed
Medium	Orange	Normal tasks (the default)
Low	Green	Nice-to-do items

Priority is a label for you; it does not change when the alert appears. You can filter by it (next section).

Each reminder also shows a status badge: **Pending** (grey), **Overdue** (red, pending and the time has passed) or **Completed** (green).

23. Reminder search and filters

The bar above the reminder cards has four controls. They work together, so a reminder must match every active control.

Control	Options	Result
Search reminders...	Type any text	Matches the title or description, ignoring upper/lower case.
Priority	All, High, Medium, Low	Shows only reminders of that priority.
Status	All, Pending, Completed	Shows only reminders with that status.
Date	Any date, Today, Upcoming	Today: reminders dated today. Upcoming: pending reminders dated today or later.

When nothing matches, the page shows *No reminders found*. Set the controls back to their first option to see all reminders.

24. Notification system

NOTE-MATE alerts you when a reminder's date and time arrive.

HOW IT WORKS

- While any NOTE-MATE page (Dashboard, Notes or Reminders) is open and you are logged in, the page checks your pending reminders when it loads and then every 30 seconds.
- When a reminder's time has arrived, an **in-app alert** box appears at the top right with the title *Reminder*, the reminder's name and when it was due (for example *Today at 10:00 AM*). Click **Dismiss** to close it.
- If you allowed browser notifications, a **system notification** is shown as well.
- Each reminder notifies **once**. After alerting, it is marked as notified in MongoDB, so it is not repeated when you refresh the page. Editing the reminder resets this so it can notify again at the new time.

ENABLING BROWSER NOTIFICATIONS

When your browser has not been asked yet, an **Enable alerts** button appears in the top bar. Click it and choose *Allow* in the browser's question. The button then disappears. If you chose *Block*, in-app alerts still work; to change your mind, allow notifications for the site in your browser's site settings.

IMPORTANT LIMITATIONS

- **Alerts need NOTE-MATE open.** If the browser or the tab is completely closed, nothing can be shown at that moment. Notifications while the browser is closed would need an email, SMS or push service, which this project does not include.
- Reminders that became due while you were away are shown once, the next time you open NOTE-MATE and are logged in.
- The check runs every 30 seconds, so an alert can be up to about 30 seconds late.
- If several NOTE-MATE tabs are open at once, you may occasionally see the same alert in more than one tab.
- The backend server must be running; if it is stopped, the page cannot check reminders.

25. Logout

Click **Logout** at the right end of the navbar (inside the Menu on small screens). Your login information is removed from the browser and you are taken to the Login page. Your notes and reminders stay saved in MongoDB. Log out when using a shared computer.

26. MongoDB and data storage overview

All data is stored in a MongoDB database (named *notemate* in the default setup). Three collections are used:

Collection	Stores	Main fields
users	One document per account	name, email (unique), password (hash), createdAt
notes	One document per note	userId, title, content, category, tags, important, createdAt, updatedAt
reminders	One document per reminder	userId, title, description, date, time, priority, completed, notificationSent, createdAt, updatedAt

- Every note and reminder carries the **userId** of its owner, and the server only ever returns documents belonging to the logged-in user.
- Passwords are saved only as bcrypt hashes. The settings in your `.env` file (database address and JWT_SECRET) are never sent to the browser.
- Your login token is kept in the browser's local storage for 7 days and removed on logout.
- To back up your data, use MongoDB tools such as *mongodump* or MongoDB Compass; the app has no export button.

27. Troubleshooting

Problem	What to try
The page will not load at all	Check the terminal: the backend must be running (`npm start`) and show *MongoDB connected*. Use http://localhost:5000.
Page says *Frontend not built yet*	The **frontend/dist** folder is missing. In the frontend folder run `npm install` and then `npm run build`, and refresh the page.
`npm install` in the frontend folder says ENOENT / no package.json	You are in the wrong folder. The backend commands are run in **backend**; the frontend folder is only needed to edit React code.
Buttons do nothing or data never appears	The backend is probably not running. Run `npm start` in the backend folder and use http://localhost:5000.
Backend stops with a MongoDB error	Start the MongoDB service (local) or check the Atlas username, password and IP access list.
Backend says MONGODB_URI or JWT_SECRET is missing	Create the `.env` file in the backend folder from `.env.example`.
Port already in use	Change PORT in .env (for example 5001) and open that port.
No reminder alerts	Keep a NOTE-MATE page open, click Enable alerts, and check that the reminder is pending and its time has passed.
Suddenly sent to Login	Your 7-day session ended or the server secret changed. Log in again.
Changes seem missing after editing code	Stop the server with Ctrl+C and run `npm start` again, then refresh the browser (Ctrl+F5).

28. Frequently encountered errors

These are the exact messages you may see and what they mean.

Message	Cause and fix
All fields are required	A registration or login field is empty. Fill in every field.
Please enter a valid email address	The email is not in a form like name@example.com.
Password must be at least 6 characters	Choose a longer password.
Passwords do not match	Password and Confirm Password differ. Retype both.
This email is already registered	An account exists for this email. Log in or use another email.
Incorrect email or password	Check spelling and caps lock. Passwords cannot be recovered.
Not logged in. Please log in first. / Session expired. Please log in again.	Your login is missing or has expired. Log in again.
Title is required / Reminder title is required	Type a title before saving.
A valid date is required / A valid time is required	Pick both a date and a time for the reminder.
Note not found / Reminder not found	It was already deleted (perhaps in another tab). Refresh the page.

Message	Cause and fix
Cannot reach the server. Make sure the backend is running (npm start).	The backend is stopped. Start it in the backend folder and keep that terminal open.
Frontend not built yet. Open a terminal in the frontend folder and run: npm install, then npm run build.	The built React app (frontend/dist) is missing. Run the two commands shown, then refresh.
Something went wrong on the server	An unexpected error. Read the terminal where the backend runs for details, check MongoDB is running, and try again.